



Blood, sweat, and smiles

Under cover of darkness, female Viet Cong guerrillas transport supplies and ammunition down a section of the Ho Chi Minh Trail in 1968 as communist forces prepare for their attack on Khe Sanh.

Operation Niagara

The Marines dug in for the siege, hunkering down in muddy bunkers strewn with garbage that attracted legions of rats. The lack of proper sanitation led to infections and disease while the constant stench and noise of explosives pushed defenders to the brink of mental breakdown.

The US responded to the initial attack and siege with the only logical means—a massive air strike. Codenamed Operation Niagara, the aerial assault entailed thousands of sorties by B-52 bombers flying from bases in Guam and Thailand and by fighter-bombers based in South Vietnam. Together they dropped more than 110,000 tons of ordnance onto NVA positions around Khe Sanh, often perilously close to the perimeter of the base itself. The vast majority of NVA troops who lost their lives during the siege were killed by this downpour of conventional bombs and napalm. The bombardment also destroyed large amounts of their weaponry and supplies of ammunition.